THE SHE LIST
UNDER 50

LEAD ESSAY

Women, Warriors, Winners

A worthy ensemble of 50 young, self-made female icons whose achievements can serve as a template for women across India and a beacon of hope for the nation

By **MANISHA SAROOP**

IN **a country where women form nearly half the population**, they may soon get a third of political representation in Parliament, the nation's highest legislative body. The implementation of the 2023 Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam could do more than bolster women's faith in Indian democracy. As more young women assume positions of power, they will not only shape the politics of today, but also the India of tomorrow.

Just look at grassroots institutions across the country to see the transformation women's empowerment can bring. Currently, India has some 1.45 million elected women representatives in its Panchayati Raj Institutions. That is 46 per cent of the total, the highest for women in local governance in the world. Dolly, the 36-year-old sarpanch of Sadipur village in Bihar, remembers only too well when she took over the *gram kachahari* (village court) to resolve local disputes. People would initially walk past her and toward her husband, assuming he was in charge, given how common proxy representation is a reality across India's rural swathes. But Dolly let her work speak for itself and soon left no one in doubt who was calling the shots.

In another Bihar village—Tilkari in Munger district—Bina Devi first discovered the value of financial independence herself and then proceeded to share it with women in a hundred other villages. When scientists from a neighbouring agricultural university came to train women in mushroom farming, the then Tilkari sarpanch turned the skill into an engine of enterprise not just for her own family but for women across the region.

Sometimes, a seemingly small intervention by a woman in power can go a long way in improving the everyday existence of women around her. IAS officer Hari Chandana Dasari played that role in Telangana. As district collector of Narayanpet, she observed how the local women had stopped going to the weekly market because there was nowhere for them to relieve themselves during the day. Hari Chandana had a 'She-toilet' installed at the market, and the locals can't thank her enough for it.

Dolly, Bina and Hari Chandana are among the 50 women under 50 we are featuring in our Independence Day special issue this year. As INDIA TODAY magazine completes 50 years of publication, we decided to celebrate

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**